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Virginia Board of Education, Public Charter School Standing Committee, Thursday, May 8, 2025

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[00:10:53] Hello, my name is Mache Ashton, and I'd like to call this meeting to order. President Creasy, should I throw it over to you? Yes, that's fine. Okay. All right. Thank you. Good afternoon, everyone.

[00:11:10] I am Grace Creasy. I'm the president of the Board of Education, and I'm joining today to facilitate this meeting and serve as an ex-officio member. Before we get started, I will note for the record that I have approved the remote participation of Mache Ashton under the board bylaws in 2.2.3708.3B4 of the Code of Virginia due to a personal matter, which identifies with the specificity of the nature of this personal matter.

[00:11:40] So, Ms. McDaniel, would you call the role of members of the standing committee, please? Yes, Madam President. Ms. Mache Ashton? Present. Mr. Chris Ronlett? Present. Mr. Antoine Green. Present. Ms. Ebony Lee.

[00:11:57] Present. Ms. Nina Reese. Absent. Okay. We have a quorum, and we will begin this afternoon with the Pledge of Allegiance, followed by a moment of silence. I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:12:36] Okay. All members of the Standing Committee were provided with an agenda in advance of this meeting. Is there a motion to approve the agenda? So moved. Second. Those in favor indicate by saying aye. Aye. Any opposed? Okay. Members of the standing committee were provided with the minutes in advance of this meeting. From the previous meeting is there a motion to approve the minutes

[00:13:12] from the July 2024 meeting? So moved. All those in favor? Any opposed? Okay. The standing committee accepts public comment on all matters related to public charter schools in Virginia. Public comment is an important consideration and a valued input to the public charter school standing committee public charter school standing committee will accept public comments on agenda items at this section of the agenda public comment on non agenda items will be accepted upon the conclusion of the business portion of this meeting should there be multiple members of the public seeking to comment

[00:13:52] on a specific agenda item or non agenda item commenters will be recognized in the order in which their request was received by the Department of Education for the benefit of the committee and public record I would ask that commenters please state your name and organization at the beginning of your remarks comments will be limited to three minutes given the time and cost to travel and again for the benefit of the public record the public charter school standing committee welcomes and encourages the public to submit written comments to the committee as a reminder written comments may be submitted on the web form available on the standing committees page on the Department of

[00:14:29] Education website. All comments received through the web form will be provided to the Public Charter School Standing Committee in advance of its next meeting. We have received five written comments today. Members of the Standing Committee have been provided with those comments as they pertain to the agenda item A. Is there anyone in the audience that would like to provide public comment today? Well you're next. You're not you're not public. Anyone in the room would like to provide public charter school comments okay i will close the public comment

[00:15:06] section okay we will be getting ready to turn to item a but i would like to ask superintendent emily ann gullickson if she would please address the committee thank you madam president chair ashton and members of the standing committee i'm here today as state superintendent of public instruction to mark the importance of this day and to say thank you for your service

[00:15:37] Ensuring every student has access to an excellent school where their needs, interests, and learning style are honored is key to having a robust system of public schools. To that end, the Governor and the General Assembly have encouraged our schools to modernize and build options within their existing schools and communities that best meet the needs of their students and families.

[00:16:00] However, we also are excited about the opportunity to welcome more educators like those here today who are willing to do the hard work of launching their own public school models and have something special to offer students and families in their community. This is precisely why Virginia has a public charter school law and why today is so important.

[00:16:21] Harbor School and their founder are taking this leap and putting a school model up for review that has been successfully piloted. Now it is your job to review their model and I appreciate all of the hard work that has gone into evaluating their readiness. This is a thoughtful evaluation process in the Commonwealth of Virginia to ensure that we always strive to have the best network of public schools in the country and making room for new ideas and great schools that truly meet the needs of every child.

[00:16:49] Thank you as always for doing your part. Thank you Superintendent Gallickson and now we will be turning to agenda item a consideration of a public charter school application from the harbor school at the outside out sorry at the outset i remind members of the committee and members of the public that pursuant to virginia's public charter school statute 22.1-212.9 the public charter school standing committee will discuss the extent to which the application satisfies the board's

[00:17:23] established criteria and ultimately will take a consensus vote requiring a majority on each of the four criterion and then a fifth and final vote on the overall application. These four criterion and then a fifth and final vote on the overall application will be measured through number one feasibility, number two curriculum, number three financial soundness, number four other objective criterion. These are outlined in the evaluation rubric that each member of the committee has in their possession. If the committee agrees

[00:18:00] by consensus that the criteria are satisfied, the application will be presented to the Board of Education. Any comments oral or written made here will be presented to the board and incorporated into feedback for the public charter school applicant to consider. If the committee decides that not all criteria are satisfied, the applicant may be provided time to address those. Within 10 business days following the public charter school standing committee, department staff and the chairman of the committee will prepare a report summarizing the committee's final determination.

[00:18:38] In Virginia, the local school board is the final authorizer. Therefore, if the public charter school application satisfies the board's criteria at the standing committee and the Board of Education, it will need to go in front of the local school division for a final vote.

[00:18:56] Today, members of this standing committee will be reviewing a public charter school application from the Harbor School. After over three years of intentional work, the Harbor School initially submitted their application in November of 2023. Now, Superintendent Gullickson, in her prior role, has worked closely with the Office of Innovation to update and adopt the current public charter school application process, the application, the evaluation rubric, to align more succinctly with the Code of Virginia and public school best practices. This work was needed as the department

[00:19:32] had not received a public charter school application in over 10 years, and the submission of the Harbor School triggered this very necessary response. I'm very, very proud of the work that the department, the board, Superintendent Gullickson, and everyone else who participated in that process. It was blood, sweat, and tears to get us where we are. And so I'm just thankful that this process has yielded the types of outcomes that we see today. Prior to the Harbor School's original submission, there had been three gubernatorial administrations, multiple state

[00:20:08] superintendents, multiple governing boards in the Commonwealth. Since this charter school standing committee had been in place and since the board had last reviewed a public school chart public charter school evaluation criteria the application all of those things had had just kind of gotten a little dusty moreover there had been a rapidly changing technology landscape with more efficient and transparent ways for us to operate and to learn from other states on best practices. These revisions to the application process, the evaluation rubric encapsulated

[00:20:47] these changes in technology to better align and reflect what is outlined in the Code of Virginia and account for these eight years of additional lessons learned when it comes to reviewing, commenting, supporting. We see it as our job not just to check the boxes and to review this for you all, but to also ensure

that we have the very best public charter schools in the nation and we are going to work to that end. The Virginia Board of Education approved these updated materials at the July 2024 Board of Education meeting and replaced

[00:21:23] those antiquated and outdated processes. After this approval revised materials were provided to all of the applicants and the department staff began offering weekly charter school office hours which we were really proud of. The Harbor School team took advantage of this technical support and has worked with the department for almost a year putting intentional time energy and resources to greater develop and enhance their application pursuant to the new public charter school process now i will turn it over to miss mcdaniel to tell you more about the harbor school

[00:21:57] so i will let miss mcdaniel take it away thank you thank you madam president good afternoon madam president madam chair and members of the committee i present to you today agenda item a consideration of a public charter school application from the harbor school an innovative public charter school model set to be based in richmond after receiving the revised public charter school application process application and evaluation rubrics the harbor school has sought out technical support from the department on numerous occasions for almost a year including meetings with our office of assessment our office of accountability and our office of special

[00:22:35] populations. Furthermore, since August, the Office of Innovation has provided weekly public charter school office hours, and the Harbor School has regularly taken advantage of these opportunities for technical support. On March 13, 2025, an enhanced public charter school application was received by the department from the Harbor School. Pursuant to the public charter school application process, the Harbor School application was subsequently sent to Chair Ashton. Thereafter, I completed my review of administrative completeness and notified the applicant and Chair Ashton

[00:23:09] of the same. On March 31, 2025, the application was forwarded to all members of the Public Charter School Standing Committee for their thorough review. Members of the Standing Committee will use this time today to listen to a prepared presentation from the applicant and engage in a dialogue with the applicant regarding their application. The Harbor School is a public charter school proposed city in Richmond. The Harbor School has been rooted in expertise that comes from the lived expertise of young people and families who want and need different educational opportunities, as well as the expertise that comes from the professional experience of educators.

[00:23:46] The Harbor School is part of the movement for learn-centered education, which has shown strong results nationwide for students who have historically struggled in traditional models. The Harbor School is the result of over four years of investment, contributions from over 175 people in over 4,200 hours of design, implementation, and reflection. The Harbor School team has conducted more than 150 interviews, dozens of design sessions, and several pilot programs in the form of learning pods with youth caregivers, youth development staff, and educators. These pilots were conducted to establish feasibility as required by statute

[00:24:23] by a proof of concept. The Harbor School team is led today by Ms. Sarah Craig. Ms. Craig is the lead community founder of the Harbor School. Ms. Craig comes from a family of Virginia educators and principals. Over the last six years, Ms. Craig has convened over 175 stakeholders to supervise 4,200 hours of pilot programs and research to inform the model of this public charter school. Madam President,

Madam Chair, and members of the committee, I now turn it over to Ms. Sarah Craig to present to you the Harbor School. Ms. Craig, thank you.

[00:25:03] project my voice. Can you hear me? I've got a microphone coming. Great. Yay. Mache, can you

[00:26:05] hear? Wonderful. Okay, Sarah, why don't you talk through that? Can you still hear me? Chair Ashton? Great. Yes. Okay, good. Thank you. Madam President, Chair Ashton, Superintendent Gollickson, members of the committee, it's been a minute to get here. Thank you for being here. Thank you for the thoughtful process. I'm so glad to be here as the convener of a community of founders.

[00:26:32] that is bringing you this model of the Harbor School. Professionally, my background is in nonprofit management, fundraising, youth development, business. Personally, my background is in public schools in Virginia. Four generations of my family have been public school educators in the state of Virginia and educators who not only cared deeply about young people getting the academic outcomes that they needed, but also cared about them as whole people.

[00:27:02] My family was interested in youth development before we had the word, and shown a real commitment to doing that. I like to say that education was the family business, and I'm real grateful to be here to talk you through the journey that got us to the Harbor School Learning Model, to talk you through a high-level understanding of the competency-based model that we have, and most importantly, to let a few other really important voices speak today, and then to answer questions.

[00:27:28] This journey really starts a long time ago. I grew up, as I mentioned, in a family of educators. School for me was a second home. I loved going to school. And because I loved being there, I was able to capture what school offered to me.

[00:27:43] When I moved to Richmond 25 years ago, nearly, I began to live and to work in communities that were very different from my own, mostly low-income, mostly African-American communities. And what I learned in working with students and talking to families is that young people didn't have that same feeling I did when they went to their schools.

[00:28:02] And it made it more difficult for them to capture that which school was offering. I heard a lot of stories, but I think of one. There was a little girl that lived in my neighborhood. She was in third grade, spent a lot of time at our house, and she said to me just before Christmas, here's what I would really like from you for Christmas, Sarah.

[00:28:24] I would really like a book that I can read. So I bought her the second grade level reading book. She climbed up on the couch that Christmas morning, and she said to me, that's great. Now teach me to read it. That young woman didn't make it out of middle school, and that story has haunted me, along with many others that I heard over those years.

[00:28:46] And in 2018, there were a group of us who worked together here in Richmond that decided it was time to take these voices seriously. And we began to do very serious interviews and conversations with students, with families, with young alumni to really understand what was going on and to begin to seek solutions.

[00:29:03] One of those young women told me a story about how she had gone to open high school here in Richmond and had been a decent student but did not learn to love learning until she went to Howard

University. At Howard, she found identity, she found connection to learning, she found that she could learn to write in a class about something she was interested in.

[00:29:22] And then she said this, I don't think it's fair I had to pay all that money to learn to love to learn, and what about my friends and others who could not do that? So we began to think about what does this comment mean, and we got together a group of young people and said, pick a project and work on it.

[00:29:38] And we got with some educators and said, what traditional academic things can we teach in this program? And we selected students who had not loved school, who had not been connected to school, who had lower academic achievement. And what we found was that those young people couldn't wait to learn to do research.

[00:29:55] They couldn't wait to learn to write good questions. They couldn't wait to do the academic things on the way to this project that they really cared about. Not one of them finished their project. There is no way to build a whole business in the summer. That's okay. What they did learn was these academic skills, and we saw them really wanting to learn.

[00:30:11] We also saw them have agency. at the end they said, I think I know how to manage my future. Just as that finished, there was a mom who came to us and said, I have some middle school students that I send to the corner store and they get ripped off because they can't count money. Can you help them? That comment turned into a math camp as it happened during COVID. Here's what's crazy about marketing during COVID. We said to kids, want to come to a math camp? They said, yes, please. 30 of them came in the eastern part of Richmond and the eastern part of Henrico County with pretty big gaps in their math skills.

[00:30:45] What we found is after 30 years, 30 years, nope, 30 hours of work in math, particularly fun games and approachable learning, learning that was the right size challenge, their persistence and problem solving grew from an average of 45 seconds when we started to 30 minutes in that small investment of time.

[00:31:06] they then arrived ready to learn at the end of that math camp the same mom said to me you've seen my young people I don't think they can learn online so we partnered with a local non-profit to do a homeschool pod for what ended up being two years lots of learning in that time but one of the biggest takeaways was a youth development focused environment plus high quality academics resulted in really remarkable growth and being able to personalize that learning to find the spots where kids had gaps, and give them not only the academic learning, but also the skills around

[00:31:41] that made them curious kids, and also got them learning quickly. So what we found was that in about a nine-month period, kids learned about two and a half years worth of math once we found that moment for them. At the end of that, I again said, I think we're done here. And Tanya Robinson said, I've got a kindergartner, and I've been knocking on the doors in my neighborhood.

[00:32:07] And when we counted it up, 70% of the people that she talked to said, I have a kid that I know that could use a learning experience like this. We'd love to help you make a school. So this school should be a public school. By the time we ended those four years of investment, we are missing a slide. And there were, nope, well, let me tell you about this.

[00:32:28] We went and looked and did some research, too, to make sure that what we were seeing in our neighborhood was not isolated to that neighborhood. This is, over the last 10 years, the gap that has grown

between white students in Richmond public middle schools and black and Hispanic students in Richmond public middle schools.

[00:32:45] The gap this year was about 27%. It's growing at a rate of 2.5% a year over this time period. Rating scores are more alarming. We have an average gap of 47% over the last 10 years, and this gap is also growing at a rate of 1.5%.

[00:33:01] It's unacceptable that only 44% of our African American students are reading at grade level in eighth grade, going into the important years of their learning. When we see the magnitude of what's happening, we knew it wasn't just the neighborhood we were working on. By the time we got to this point, we had a whole crowd of people who really cared about this, from parents to educators to students, and that brings us here to the model of the Harbor School, asking ourselves, what can we do to change this story?

[00:33:29] A Harbor School learning model is built in a learner-centered design where educators and students build learning together. And it is a competency-based model rather than a time-based model. We started with outcomes in mind.

[00:33:47] The first thing that we knew that young people needed and wanted from our interviews was they wanted to be designers of their own futures. They need these skills in order to get where they're going in life. They have to be great, competent, curious learners. need to master the fundamental literacies and the content but they also need to drive their own learning and be super curious going forward and have the skills to do that and we want them to be active community members that might mean joining you all on the dais someday but it also means having the ability to know who they are and how to relate in very different communities that they

[00:34:22] will face whether that's a family a workplace a neighborhood etc being able to get along with people is super important. We knew we wanted to keep core academics central. We have a lot of young people with a lot of gaps at a lot of different places, and so we needed to keep academics in the center, but we also needed to add these other competencies. A competency-based environment allows us to personalize learning so that academics can be used to teach these other things, interests and well-being, executive function, how to work on relationships while using the difficulty of learning to our advantage. It also allows us to make sure that young people

[00:34:59] have right-sized challenges. We think of this as the Goldilocks of learning. Challenging enough to be interesting, but not so challenging that I won't approach it. It's when we are based in a time-based environment where the curriculum moves on, it's very easy to get stuck in a system of plan, instruct, practice, grade, move on. When we work in this environment, we can add some steps to this along the lines of feedback before we assess, reflection afterwards before we move to the next lesson, and evaluation of where we should start. And it is this reflection that allows young people

[00:35:34] to really know what it means to learn and to get to a place of mastery. When we get to mastery, not only do the learning coaches know that a young person knows because they've seen it, the student also does and can apply that to the next lesson, building their confidence. It's easy to imagine that personalized learning pathways means being on a computer all the time that's not what we mean in fact at the beginning we may not even have a lot of technology as kids learn to think and learn to learn built into the model are skill building workshops and some play-based

[00:36:08] learning place-based experiences multi-disciplinary projects that make sense of the world for young people that in their adolescence are beginning to want to do that and to be ready to do that we also needed to add to the designation of sixth grade seventh grade and eighth grade to be able to understand a student's journey to learning so what happens here is everybody starts in what we call the orange space which is onboarding to learning and onboarding to learning the harbor way they can take a flexible amount of time to get to the next space into a yellow set of competencies

[00:36:44] that have been stacked appropriately in our bite size giving us the ability to be really transparent with young people, with learning coaches, and with families about the pace at which competencies are growing. Academic pacing continues at the 6th, 7th, 8th grade. This is a way of getting all the competencies to be visible to students. And no, we can't do that in a typical classroom with a teacher and 20 students. So here's how it works. You take one student, one learner, and they are a part of a cohort of 8 to 12 learners with one learning coach who is watching for their entire development they stay with that learning coach likely their time during the

[00:37:24] Harbor School that is the the majority of students should do that one cohort is paired with two others to form an anchor group of three so now you have about 24 students and three instructors three learning coaches who are primarily working with that and they have diverse learning skills I want to be really clear here that doesn't mean that a math teacher teaches reading it is that these are taking a look at what's happening overall as the student goes to math class as the student works in reading this is the watching for the whole child these three anchor groups come together in a pod of 108 and each

[00:38:03] pod has a family liaison that makes sure that we're talking with families on a weekly basis and building those relationships asking families what can you tell us that we need to know about your child as much as we're telling you what you need to know about their learning experience. Three pods form a whole Harbor School, and we have a head of school, a dean of instruction, and a wellness director to ensure that we're paying attention to the entire school, meaning the head of school is here for administration, for watching, for finances, for looking at compliance, leaving a dean of instruction to be fully present to the academic learning of our young people

[00:38:39] and their teachers. The wellness director is more focused on adults than on young people, although available for supportive relationship building in partnership but really paying attention to secondary trauma for teachers paying attention to teacher and staff well-being we also have several specialists in the disciplines to support all the learning pathways making sure that they are getting where we need to go in the end it's a 12 to 1 learner to learner to coach ratio for certified teachers if we count the additional specialists in the building who are more on the

[00:39:15] developmental side it gets down to about an eight to one ratio and we're open 184 school days per year that gets us to a little more than 180 but paced out over an entire school year and eight hours per day let me show you what this looks like there's a video showing behind you you may need to peek at let me see if I can go back let's try this again here we're visualizing a pod of students and you'll see them we call them our four heroes

[00:39:53] here who've just arrived and had breakfast with their cohort they move into their morning meeting to get ready for the day they go to their individual spaces to do their planning and to get started before they move about their plan that's been pre-planned in advance that would last them probably a trimester as they move about the place what you'll see is they move on their own pathways that but they

move in relationship with other students and other teachers importantly learning is ordered in the way that makes sense for them most students do what is most difficult for them in the morning and

[00:40:29] save the easy stuff for later and two longer learning blocks that it that allow students to move into the different rotations that they need at the end of the day they go back into where they started to do a reflection and a plan for the next day before they head for their final PE class if that's what suits them or perhaps out to an elective off-site whoo that's a lot and for an enrollment plan we start small there's a lot to build here competency-based

[00:41:07] models exist throughout the country and there are tools that need to be built based on what they've done we need students in the room to do that so we start with a small group of 448 students and we grow as quickly as we can to 324 those first two years grow slowly and then we believe we can accelerate growth to get to 324 which brings us to a sustainable financial model so when you think about from an income perspective year one on a per student basis as it is with any school that starting the Harbor School is more expensive than the average cost in that first year when we count year zero costs plus year one

[00:41:47] costs community donations will need to cover about two-thirds of that cost that first year the direct cost for donations is about a third of the income by year five we're in the range of two to three percent of income coming from donations and the in this school being supported on the average per people spend that exists in Richmond right now adjusted for inflation in fact it's a slightly less than what is currently being spent as you can see in the expense slide you can see that it's a little bit less expensive than an inflation-based rate

[00:42:23] of increase for what Richmond public schools on average is spending now on operating additionally we're able to pay for some renovation cost should we be able to acquire a Richmond public schools building that needs renovation we would be able to pay for about a 12 million dollar debt service on that and ask community donations to support that facility cost should that be the way things play out which brings us to here standing in front of you to have some more conversation but before I we close let me let you speak hear from a few of the voices that have been along the way so it's not just mine

[00:43:03] Hello, everyone. My name is Bumi Esho, and I am a community founder at the Harbor School as well as part of the management committee. I have over 20 plus years of experience as an engineer, an educator, a nonprofit leader, and now a small business owner here in Richmond, Virginia.

[00:43:34] And for me, particularly when I think of my work as a STEM educator, it has been about the experiences not only of the learner, as mentioned by Sarah, but also the families.

[00:43:52] I believe and I know, particularly as someone who studied engineering and was an engineer, that being able to think around curriculum that is relevant and also interest-based is important. And so what I see, particularly with the Harbor School, is them being able to, us really being able to center that for all the learners, for the families, so that it becomes a community role and it becomes something where we're all learning and we're all lifting ourselves up in terms of that learning.

[00:44:28] And so I see really the value and the power of being able to have solutions like the Harbor School as additional pieces to our education here in Richmond. Thank you.

[00:44:44] Good afternoon. My name is Jonathan Vibbs. I am happy to be a member of the Management Committee at the Harbor School. I'm a native Richmonder, born and raised, a product of Richmond Public Schools, graduated from Huguenot High School, go Falcons.

[00:45:05] For 20 years, I've been involved in education in Richmond. I am the former CEO of Richmond Prep, which is one of the oldest African-American-led private schools in the Commonwealth. but i'm here today to represent some voices who are not able to be here to participate in this conversation we have two of our community founders who are students you'll see them in the picture on the screen those two students are in class right now taking tests two of our community

[00:45:40] founders are working moms and they aren't able to take off at 12 o'clock on a middle of a work day to come be a part of a meeting like this. But these voices are not just important because they are the ones who have shaped the Harbor School, but they represent the very kinds of people that need access to an innovative school model. And in Virginia, the charter school law is the vehicle that allows them to participate in the creation of an environment that works for their children.

[00:46:17] My heart is for Richmond and specifically for what some would call the least and the lost in our community. And if you look at the history of our city, when it comes down to education, all the way back to reconstruction, all the way through the 20th century, you find Richmonders being innovative in how they approach education.

[00:46:43] You find people like A.V. Norrell, you find people like Virginia Randolph, and then you see how educators and Armstrong and Walker High Schools had to evolve and shape curriculum and find ways to serve the students that were in front of them.

[00:47:00] We even innovated in the 70s. We had the complex, Jefferson Huguenot with, and then we had Open High School, Richmond Community High School. And we see the Harbor School as an opportunity for us to reclaim that history of educational innovation.

[00:47:18] And we're really excited about the opportunity to present this, not just to the state, but to our city and hear more from our community about what this school could do for the kids of our city so thank you this has been a deeply team effort so thanks for letting me have some other people speak you'll see on this last slide the key aspects of competency-based education that we think is a really exciting thing to bring into the commonwealth particularly into the city of richmond but let's leave it there and have a

[00:47:58] conversation thank you thank you so much for that presentation miss craig um miss mcdaniel is there anything else from the department that you'd like to share before we open it up to discussion? Thank you, Madam President, Madam Chair, and members of the committee. After a review of the 33 indicators across the four criterion, the department feels that the public charter school applicant has submitted the documentation and evidence to meet the threshold of the board's evaluation criteria. I am available for questions, as is Ms. Craig's team, as you discuss and vote

[00:48:31] each of the boards evaluation criteria okay so we've heard quite a bit of information from the department received extensive materials prior to this meeting from the Harbor School to include both this presentation and the application the department and the applicant have both completed the work that we asked them to do and now it's time to have the required committee discussion um and so with that i would um open up the floor for discussion and questions excuse me madam president i'm going to ask members of the harbor school team to join us

[00:49:11] ashton please jump in should you have anything to question or comment on since i can't see you

[00:49:45] the team can yeah thank you i can see the group so thank you okay um yes uh president i will jump I first just want to thank and congratulate the team for a thorough presentation but really just the hard work it seems that you really gathered input from community members stakeholders it's been a clear labor of love and having founded a school I want to say I know how hard it has been just to plan but wait till you open. As you just reflected on this process, I know that you've

[00:50:24] been doing it for a long time. Can you just talk about, you know, what do you think are going to be some of the, let's just call it, top two or three biggest challenges as you think about what's next? Yeah, I'll jump in. We'll try to limit it, Chair Ashton, to two or three. You know, I think I think there are I'm going to mention two and I'll let you all add to it I think one of them is and just the continuing challenge of doing something that hasn't been done

[00:50:58] for we haven't opened a public charter school that's community created since 2010 there's a lot of learning to do just along the way and from legislative bodies like the school board learning in Richmond how to do this to our own learning curve we're really fortunate to have had the time we've had to build a strong team around us the people to advise and people to help and people who are excited about this but we're gonna need to be patient through that process I think another piece that we're gonna spend a lot of time thinking about is what is the right location the particular location we're not still not exactly certain and given

[00:51:38] that we hope to open in fall 26 it's been too early to be able to sign a lease on something to start with but finding a location that meets the standards of quality that we know that we need to have plus is accessible to the young people that we know we want to reach is is going to be something that we work hard at there are a number of options out there but that will be a place where we spend a lot of time making sure that that works for all of the pieces that are required those are two of the pieces that I think I think the third one probably has to do with onboarding our learning coaches to a new way of

[00:52:14] teaching and learning and we will spend our year zero which for us will begin sometime in the fall even as we work with the Richmond Public School Board to bring some young people in for pilot experiences Saturdays spring break summer camp etc this summer to really practice this this way of working with students we'll partner with the learner centered collaborative we believe to help us with that coaching but really onboarding adults as well as as young people to a new way of doing things will be a challenge and a high priority for us

[00:52:50] moving forward. Did I miss anything? Thank you. Thank you. Chair Creasy, President Creasy, I'll let other members of the committee who I can't see but I'm grateful that they're there in person and I've asked some more questions, and I may have some follow-up.

[00:53:07] Thank you. Others? Ms. Lee? Thank you all for your presentation, and I will echo the chair's admiration for all the hard work that has gone into where we are today. So I just want to follow up on something you mentioned in your presentation, and that is that you began this journey with the outcomes in mind.

[00:53:30] You have a very unique model that you are proposing. And so I would like for you guys to walk us through how you landed on like trimesters as the mode for this proposed school.

[00:53:47] Which of us do you want? So great question. One of the things that we struggled with is this idea that learning is flexibly paced, but it can't take forever.

[00:54:04] And so we need natural demarcation points to get students and teachers to chase. And so a more rapid turning of the time with a trimester than a semester really pushes the learning to move a little bit faster and gives us a faster point for evaluation.

[00:54:22] We can't have young people moving from one chunk of learning to the next every day of the week. That causes chaos. Nor do we want them moving at the end of a year. So a trimester was a space to really accelerate that process of getting to the next chunk of learning. It also gave us an opportunity to take a break from the intensity so we can have a little bit of a longer break there for a week or two for people to rest, recover, and then come back strong.

[00:54:50] So that was the logic behind those trimesters. Did I? I would just add to that that it really builds in a natural space for the educators to reflect on what happened, tidy up all the record keeping that's required, and map out the next trimester instead of packing everything into one semester. I'd also add just knowing that it's trimesters, the gaps between or the spaces really between the breaks is shorter. And so when you think around learning loss, there's a lot of data around that you know as well and um i know just from my experiences having lived in california

[00:55:30] and saw saw schools like that that would have actually more of a year long as they saw it versus that traditional two months break during the summer so being able to to consider that thank you further questions mr bronick thank you um i appreciate it let me just background on on myself i was a member of Fairfax County School Board back at the dawn of what was then the charter school

[00:56:06] years in Virginia and and I considered myself and I was and I remain very much supporter of charter schools because I think that they provide additional options for children particularly children in need and I'm a supporter even when I don't necessarily understand everything that's being put on the table because we need some innovation and because the real key to to all of this in a child's education is really the personnel and leadership of the institution that is driving them forward. And clearly, you all meet that qualification in spades.

[00:56:46] I think charter schools have been around in this country for 33 years. In Virginia, they're still considered mysterious, new. Some people consider them dangerous. Some people consider them a panacea. So it's important that in the few that we have that we make certainly operate strongly. Let me ask you, I've got to actually, in reading through this, I ended up with more questions and conclusions, but let me start with this one. At the end, you will get a contract if you're approved by RPS, because Richmond Public Schools are the only institution

[00:57:19] that can approve you. It will be for a length of time. At the end of that contract, how will you determine whether Harbor School has been successful in its mission? Are you planning a benchmark assessment of each child that enters going to try to assess where they are when they leave whether it's at seventh grade or eighth grade what talk to me a little bit about that sure um it's a great question and we really really feel passionately that the harbor school be held to excellence and we really really feel passionately that um if what we are innovating

[00:57:59] isn't meeting the needs of young people and getting them to be excellent learners that we don't continue. So it's a really good question. I think there's a couple of areas that are really important to us. The first is absolutely growth. I think it'll be really important that we have a clear understanding of where young people come in and where they leave. But let me be clear, we expect some pretty high performance on state assessments in eighth grade. We expect people to really catch up while they're with us if they start

from behind. So we feel like eighth grade performance is a is a meaningful number and something that we'll be working hard towards

[00:58:33] we also would love to see the input from parents and young people about their experiences be a measure of success the school is intended to respond to needs and express desires of young people if we're not meeting that mark that is important as well if every kid is learning and every kid is miserable then we haven't achieved our objective so we would think about growth we would think about that final assessment and we would think about the demand part of how that's

[00:59:04] going and how school is being experienced. Thank you. So if you, one of the arguments I've always made, having represented an area that had sons of daughters and sons of doctors and lawyers and sons of people working two incomes, was that, do you plan an assessment when they enter the school so you know where they are you're going to use the old their their last SOL score I mean what

[00:59:35] kind of assessment will you use because a student might end up in eighth grade at 50 percentile but they might have started at 20 correct and and so your need to measure the growth as much as anything else that's right I'm gonna let an educator details on the evaluation part um I think it comes I think it comes down to the onboarding process which is lengthy we're spending a lot of time one-on-one with each child during that period and we're really learning where they are

[01:00:10] my background in tutoring has shown me that you can you can understand a lot about a child when you have a conversation with them about what they're trying to do and you can you can really get them started on the path and then we have periods of throughout the year we have three conferences with their learning team to see here's where they were here's where we thought they'd be what do we need to adjust in their learning path um and i think if the question is which precise evaluation that's not an answer we can give you today but will there be one absolutely yes really

[01:00:49] critical madam president if i may thank you a couple of things that that stood out and and were question marks for me because i didn't understand them you are proposing a system for dual lotteries one for those who are economically disadvantaged and one for those who are not.

[01:01:09] And it appears to me that there are spaces being allocated according to the RPS definition of the different school demographics. There can be a lot of reasons for doing that. The generous reason would be to say you want to make certain you're reaching the students you're trying to reach.

[01:01:30] The ungenerous explanation which people will use is that you are seeking to gain the students coming in so you look better. Can you elaborate a little bit more on that? Absolutely. I appreciate that.

[01:01:46] Our conversation, the reason that is there is because we really do want to make sure that we're reaching the young people that we intend to reach. What we see in Richmond is that those schools that have options where people can apply are less likely to well they are easily accessed by those with options those are easily accessed accessed by those with resources and so we're looking for a mechanism to hold ourselves accountable to the thing that we really want which is to be available to those young people who have become disconnected from school who are more likely to be lower income i don't think that

[01:02:26] we are 100% married to that solution. If someone can help us find a better way to hold a strict number on that, then we're happy to do it. What we know that we will do is to recruit in low-income communities. What we know that we will do is to make transportation available. What we know that we

will do is to spend time working with families on the process of enrollment so that we remove that barrier. But if it were more than 65% young people who are in low-income circumstances,

[01:03:02] we'd be thrilled. It is not meant to cap that. It is meant to make sure we reach that number. And so we're looking for the right way to do that. Thank you. That's extremely comforting. Let me also ask, on page 100, you got a note that says, we look forward to continued dialogue with the VDOE, on the need for alternate means of assessment for learners who lag far behind their peers.

[01:03:33] And that's language that sort of raises red flags with me because it suggests the kind of words I heard when I was president of the state board as I was going out the door and there was a new administration coming in.

[01:03:49] Can you elaborate on what you mean by that, what the nature of the kind of alternative assessments that you're planning and your profile of the students you think is it just low scores or is it is it ell is it special education with for which they're already alternate talk a little bit about that and flesh that out for me me too um so the thinking there is the number so we had um during our homeschool pod and during our math camp we were working with about 40 students that live in

[01:04:23] the neighborhoods that we would want to be in. More than half of them as sixth and seventh graders were on a first and second grade level for math. Two of six seventh graders couldn't read their letters and make sounds out of their letters, being just, to be frank, grossly behind where they needed to be. And so that conversation is really about what do we do in those circumstances, It's not the young person who's maybe at a fifth-grade level when they're in the middle of sixth grade, not even a student who's in a fourth-grade level when they come into sixth grade.

[01:05:00] But what about those young people that we find to be that far behind? And how do we create an opportunity for them to be successful and to feel successful as they make those leaps and acknowledge that growth?

[01:05:16] I think we see an assessment system that is taking account for growth, So we're not really worried about it on the sense of, like, will we be judged incompetent? It is more about what are the things that we do when students have fallen that far behind that acknowledge that this happens and work towards that.

[01:05:35] I think the second piece that's behind that, and as you read it to me, I think, hmm, it could have been a little clearer, is this idea of a competency-based model does ask us to think about assessment long-term in a different way. With one school that's competency-based in Virginia, we're not suggesting we ought to wire ourselves around that.

[01:05:55] But it is a conversation that we ought to have over time. How do we appropriately acknowledge the many competencies that young people are learning? And how do we assess that a little differently? Kristen, would you want to add anything to the competency-based assessment part?

[01:06:13] I mean, I think you covered it. But the big idea is that when you have the assessments that are made for a certain grade level, but our kids are tackling competencies, tackling little by little where they are, it feels silly to place them in front of the wrong test when the right test does exist.

[01:06:36] So it would be great to at some point have a conversation about how the test could be matched to the stuff they've been working on in that moment. And to add, I think that it's also a measure of how do

you say okay, and I think Sarah had mentioned this as well, that they've been successful.

[01:06:58] So over, like, the course of a year, if they've gone from competency of, like, first grade level to fourth grade level, is there a way to be able to measure that in shape and let them know that, wow, you have done so much well. You have improved so much, you know, from that point on.

[01:07:17] And so being able to really just elevate that success of that learner and be able to continuously find ways to kind of test that level of improvement. Let me just add one more sentence, which is we also don't want to be heard as sympathizing kids into failure.

[01:07:40] That doesn't mean, oh, you're at first grade, let's get you to second grade by the end of the year. Absolutely not. Let's continue to move you to the place that you need to be as rapidly as possible. So I hope you won't hear meeting a student where they are as being unrigorous. In some ways, it's being more rigorous.

[01:07:56] Let's get you where you need to be. So are we talking about alternative assessments, or are we talking about additional evaluations that would better inform the instruction of the teacher moving forward? At the end of the day, they have to take the SOLs.

[01:08:12] At the end of the day, like every public school, the school will be assessed on it. Correct. and we're happy for that to happen we're just also happy to keep talking about what's great assessment okay well over time because the word alternative means instead of yes and and and i think that is potentially problematic for a lot of reasons across the board and you might want to to better flesh that out a little more understood in your um i'll try to make this the last one There's a line at the bottom of page 116 marked stipends and one marked bonuses and incentive pay.

[01:08:53] I'm wondering if you could explain the difference between those by what you mean and how they would be applied to get the best out of your staff and your personnel. I think I know what you mean, but I don't know that I know what you mean. I'll make the page number. Let me make sure. 116.

[01:09:10] Yes. So we're thinking there about two different things. a stipend being you're taking on an additional responsibility of some kind, be that the coach of the robotics team or whatever else, that it's something additional that you're doing to make school work. Something that would be a bonus or incentive pay might be around getting an additional credential that would bump up your salary or give you a reward for going to learn that it might be you're leading a teaching a learning session with your peers and so it's

[01:09:48] incentivized to to do something on that it doesn't necessarily tie to your kids scores because it's a group teaching environment it has more to do with the ways that we invest in ourselves as a as a as an rp you'll be an rps school you fall under the collective bargaining agreement is i no stipends are permitted. They're specified in the RPS CBA. Are incentives like the second

[01:10:18] group that you mentioned permitted? I think that's a good question, and it's something that we aren't, it's something that we'll have to negotiate along with another, many other parts of the model and under the collective bargaining agreement. For instance, things like, I think the most recent one has something like 21 minutes of lunch for instance there's some details that won't that don't work exactly in the model and so I think all of those things we will be flexible to work

[01:10:55] with um the collective bargaining agreement to do what makes sense I know you had some thoughts about that I can tell you I spent a year working as a union organizer for the AFL-CIO and I can tell you that we're going to be worker friendly and care about people so we're going to we're going to be quick to talk to teachers about what is good for them and what's going to make the workplace a space that they feel comfortable in. I hope it'll make the teachers union feel comfortable. I mean, because, I mean, it's the, the, the conflict between collective bargaining

[01:11:30] agreements and charter school operations across the country is legendary. And, and I'd hate to see that get started right there. My other question is, have you plugged in the right numbers in your assumptions about salary increases as you move forward? Because it looked to me like, given what the last, well, the current collective bargaining agreement says, it doesn't look like it's the same numbers going forward. I mean, I... Yeah, so these are based, all of these pay scales come from the

[01:12:06] most recently published personnel costs at richmond public schools as a baseline and we have selected um pay scales that are on them on the higher end seven to ten years in order to compensate for the unknown of what the increases look like we do think these numbers are still fairly conservative when you think about um the nature of newer newer faculty members coming in etc i think the salary increases are sort of akin to all the other unknowns in the budget you can

[01:12:41] plan for increases and then each year you will have to adjust to what what reality is on that front but we did choose intentionally higher pay scales to try to accommodate for um future okay more experienced teachers yeah i guess you sort of addressed it in there saying that you really haven't approached the school board members yet this is this is a highly politicized decision that the board will be making and and you certainly meet the qualifications in terms of evidence of community support although it's a little

[01:13:21] thin it's it's one basically from every category have you had any informal discussions with members of the school board and you don't have to say who just have your I mean it is not going to be easy we have begun to do some outreach to members of the school board and we've found that there are some people who are willing to hear us out we aren't under any illusion that this is going to be easy we know that there is a great deal of misunderstanding and misinformation around what charter schools are specifically in the Commonwealth of

[01:14:00] Virginia and how they differ from charter schools and other places and And we're happy to have the conversation and we're happy to tell the story about how we got to where we are in the Commonwealth around the idea of charter schools as public schools that meet the needs of students specifically.

[01:14:17] And I think making that case and helping to clear up some of that confusion, misinformation, or misunderstanding around what charter schools are, I think we're going to find some people that are going to be a little bit more willing to hear.

[01:14:33] Also, I think the Harvard School is not a top-down design school. This was developed as a response to voices from our community. We anticipate that our school leadership in the city of Richmond is going to do what they say and be responsive to the voices in our community who are asking for innovation.

[01:14:57] We are excited to hear that leaders in our city are talking about school design for the first time in a long time and we're happy to be, we see ourselves as a part of that movement toward redesigning schools in Richmond and so we're happy to have a conversation. We don't anticipate it being easy but we do think that we can be successful.

[01:15:20] And there is conversation behind the scenes with several members who are willing to be supportive and thinking about the best strategic way to do that. And I think you've identified that they are responsive to what they hear from the community.

[01:15:35] So I guess my only suggestion, some of those letters in there are two years old. It may well be time for you to ramp up your local activities and hit the dry cleaners and the churches and the street fairs and let parents know about what that opportunity is.

[01:15:53] At the end of the day, if a board, having been one, they don't hear from people, they can't say, I have to get out in front of them because I'm their leader. And they shouldn't, in our view, right? If the folks in Richmond are not advocating for this, then the school board shouldn't say yes.

[01:16:11] And we're really looking forward to it. We've been spending some time again in the community this last month. And the rate of one of the things that we have found is that every time we talk to people, people are excited about, can we have this right now? And what we wanted to be really careful of is that we didn't get people excited about something that you all did not approve.

[01:16:29] And we did not know how long it would take to get to this moment. How satisfied are you that you will be able to raise that money? And I'm not asking who they are, but have you got commitments at this point that will ensure your survivability?

[01:16:48] Thank you for that. And I feel really comfortable with those numbers for two reasons. The first is that we have had some conversations with some individuals who have historically been investing in programs like this in our city who are really excited to participate and not only to give but to lead fundraising for it.

[01:17:10] We also, I spent the last 20 years of my career raising money in Richmond. I raised about $60 million for out-of-school time programs in a 10-year period. That is the one thing I know how to do, and I'm really excited to give back to. anything else yes sorry thank you um if you don't mind i have a few um having been an educator

[01:17:46] in the classroom in a middle school myself for over 10 years um i'm excited to be able to participate in this committee today uh as of course um it was restarted in march of 24 is that right march of 24 um during one of our board of education meetings i wanted this committee to restart in order to get us to innovation more quickly and i do appreciate this application so i'm going to get weedy on educator stuff uh what what i really want to know about is what does

[01:18:26] remediation look like so johnny comes in at a second grade reading level you have one second grade reading level student you have five third grade five fourth grade three fifth grade help me understand what remediation looks like because that's going to look different in language arts in math in social studies in science and so having taught in inner city in Norfolk

[01:19:01] when I started my career I know how difficult it is I had an 11th grade student who couldn't read and so this is a calling to do this work and I very much appreciate it because when you were telling

those stories it took me back to stories that I experienced and people that have not experienced those moments have no idea the depth and the breadth of the people that we're not

[01:19:39] reaching in our communities and so I thank you for this I just want to know how we're getting kids from point a to where they need to be as quickly as possible because you know just life puts a lot of our kids that are going to come to y'all in the positions they're in but COVID has manifested that to a degree that I don't think any of us were ever, A, prepared for, or B, saw in our lifetimes. So help me understand what remediation looks like.

[01:20:15] I'm going to let Kristen answer most of that, but I want to say thank you for that question and for seeing that. I think you're right. Unless you've been with young people in those moments, that the depth of what needs to be done, it's hard to see, and it's being with them over and over and over again that helps you to see that. I think that's the reason that we're so committed to this personalized pacing and competency-based learning. It really lets us meet young people in that moment and get them moving forward more quickly.

[01:20:50] You want to talk a little bit? I think you should introduce yourself. Yeah, I'm Kristen. I've been an educator for 20 years. I have a master's in curriculum and instruction. I think the first of all everyone is on their individualized pathway so it really is much easier than in your circumstances Ms. Creasy to reach each learner where they are even if that means remediating remediation. In our homeschool pilot we had a student who it took a second to realize it but she didn't know her phonics. She was making up the words and it was she'd slipped

[01:21:30] was she in seventh grade when she came in so she would sit and read a book and i could see how in a large classroom the teacher thought she was reading and then and she read it to us we realized she wasn't um so for her what remediation looked like is she had to do with the wilson reading program she had to do phonics um for as long as she could tolerate it 15 to 30 minutes a day and she got to a point where she started to really accelerate quickly and by the end of two years she was she i mean even then she could join all the projects with everyone else she sat

[01:22:06] with kids and read a book that was really interesting with them or listened to a book that was really interesting with them um but then by the end she she really accelerated it didn't take the whole two years to catch up her phonics once she realized oh this is the code this is what i have to do it wasn't that there was actually a problem with her reading it's that she hadn't learned it um so i think there's time and flexibility to do that remediation right in the same space with everyone else you're just doing different things and everyone's doing their own thing and you're not pulled out um there's also enough teachers to do that work you know

[01:22:44] one teacher might have eight students while you're doing your 15 or 30 minutes of phonics with this other student are you asking more on structure or i think i'm i think i'm really talking about how are we identifying or how are you identifying um and then once that identification takes place what's the actual instructional plan so the identification happens during that on that you saw that orange line is that there's the first three to four weeks of school up to six weeks they're really about evaluation understanding learning how to do school in a competency-based way like there's learning that every kid needs to do on how do we do this no matter their background

[01:23:24] you can be a genius and you can be somebody who is learning to read you still got to learn how to do school this way so it gets everybody on an even pathway to start and then there is an evaluation of

each student during those weeks where we say, okay, here's some gaps that we've got and here's the plan that suits them.

[01:23:42] One of the things is we will have access to multiple curriculums that are used as resources to match to that child for what is needed right there rather than having to go through a textbook, which is hard to do in Virginia anyway because our standards are unique. You match to that child in making sure there's direct instruction where needed where a young person is behind direct instruction is going to be the right way.

[01:24:04] to do that. And then the other forms of learning, whether that's a questioning and an intuitive learning can come, but that direct instruction then happens, that learning pathway is created for that child to say, hey, let's really, let's do some front end morning work on reading and writing is the first thing for you. And you might get an hour of that, that first season of your learning versus a shorter period of time you might get an hour in the morning and 30 minutes in the afternoon to make sure that you are covering your bases on

[01:24:42] that thing that is far behind and that's where that individual pathway if you imagine it as an IEP for every student allows to meet and assess along the way the only other question that I have is talk I wanted to just hear what your professional development plan is because as a teacher just kind of want to know How is growth and development in this type of environment going to be supported as you all move through?

[01:25:14] Yeah, that's a great question. Are you guys familiar with the Learner Center Collaborative? So they have training programs for Learner Center teaching, and I think we'll begin with leaning into those trainings.

[01:25:31] And then we can actually partner with them, and they can build out a program, particularly for our school and our teachers, and we've talked to them about that. There are other trainings that we want teachers to have, too, though, besides just how to teach and do co-design with kids and design the learning experiences that they need to meet both their academics and their interests.

[01:25:54] In regards to youth development, what are some of those other trainings? make sure we have some trauma-informed trainings and ongoing one of the things that can come from the world of youth development is the importance of setting the context of learning the Weikert Center has some really nice trainings on how to make sure that we layer the important aspects of an environment it's supportive it's it's safe it's supportive there's opportunity for student engagement there's some really tools there that help us to think beyond the content of what we're doing to the experience that's wrapped around it and we've

[01:26:32] talked just recently just last week with a with a woman in town who is doing a lot of training on teachers of how to use rituals and routines to create mindfulness for students that's something that's embedded in the model that we look forward to partnering with her on and a young woman I talked with last night who does recovery and not recovery but and mindfulness and emotional recovery when we're exhausted and particularly with black educators who's excited to partner with us so we'll be looking at a 360 view to support our teachers and just like the Harvard

[01:27:07] School is individually wired for students it's individually wired for teachers to what we don't want is learning coaches sitting in the training they don't need to be in there's too much to learn there's too much to grow so those are those are personal plans too that make sure that we are growing teachers and

they're having the experience of continual learning and a say in their own development that way. Thank you. Anything else from anybody? Miss Lee, do you have any more?

[01:27:34] I do. You all helped knock some of my questions off. Forgive me if I'm a little bit all over the place, but let's just continue on the teacher track. So you talked a lot about professional development. Can you talk about what your strategy will be for recruitment? Because I think you mentioned in your opening remarks, teachers aren't necessarily taught in this style of teaching. So talk a little bit about how we might go about recruiting. And I think I read in your materials that you're seeking teachers who come to the Harvard School already with, you know, an average of like five years of experience. So talk a little bit about kind of your recruitment strategy and

[01:28:11] how you might target some of these educators. I'll leave. Let y'all follow. So I think recruitment, When we think about, so let me slow my brain on for a moment, it would be important that we have the right mix of staff.

[01:28:34] So what does that mean? It means bringing some folks who are not currently in Richmond but have experience in a learner-centered design and that competency-based model to here to learn from so that they bring some expertise with them. It will be really important that we pair that with people who know Richmond.

[01:28:53] Those of y'all who know Richmond know that Richmond is its own place, and we are Richmonders, and we know that. And so bringing that diversity of experience together will be important. We hope that we will be able to call some educators home to Richmond, people who are teaching elsewhere, to come back home.

[01:29:11] So we'll use our national network to do that. We'll use the learner-centered collaborative support to help find us the right people. We will look for, there's a handful of employees in the mix who are not certified teachers who come out of the youth development or social work space.

[01:29:28] We'll use the networks that we have to find those people. And then we'll do some real work on onboarding. The first years of the model will call for some extra learning coaches beyond what is absolutely necessary. It both provides for substitutes and for being ready for the next year as we onboard people.

[01:29:49] want to add? Yeah, having led a school and an independent school in Richmond, one thing that I can tell you is there are educators out there who in some ways are like the students that we're seeking to serve. They haven't adjusted well to the traditional environment. And some of those teachers would love the opportunity to get back in the classroom that's not traditional. So as One is bringing some teachers home from outside of the area.

[01:30:22] We think there may be some teachers that we can bring back to fall back in love with teaching in an environment that better suits their style or their approach. So we also think that the Harvard School is going to be, because we know that the city is also concerned, per se, that we already had a teacher shortage in the city.

[01:30:48] we don't see ourselves as this is a completely different model so we're not really looking for the same person for this classroom this model calls for a very specific kind of person so while we're not in competition with the city we do see ourselves being able to get some people back in the classroom who may have stepped out because it didn't really fit for them great I will

[01:31:17] continue. Let's talk about facility. So you mentioned that one of the challenges would be deciding the right location. My colleague mentioned that charters aren't always viewed favorably here. Are there locations that you won't consider? I'm imagining as you're having this conversation with the board that there may be some areas where folks aren't open to having

[01:31:51] a charter located so are there areas that you might be able to take off of the map in terms of where you would locate the harbor school one thing i know sarah has something to add but one thing i definitely want to say is we are committed to the harbor school being in a place where the kids are going to feel welcome in that environment in that community and we would love to see the harbor school in a community that wants to be a part of the school involved in the school so So as you said, there are some places that may not look favorably on charters.

[01:32:28] But conversely, we also don't want to move this school to places where options already exist away from the students that we're trying to serve. So we realize there's a fine balance that has to be struck there.

[01:32:45] We've had some conversations around the city around this already, and we've found some areas that are pretty excited about the opportunity. And we've been scouting to say, but we know it's a fine balance, and we're working very diligently to make sure we're in a welcoming place, but not out of reach for the students that we want to serve.

[01:33:10] And I would also add that while there is the public narrative that people are fearful of charters, and I don't want to dismiss that narrative, we did do a survey in January of voters in Richmond. And we found that right now more than 40% of voters and more than 50% of parents are favorable to charter schools.

[01:33:33] And when you explain to them what a charter school is, that number goes up dramatically. In fact, the unfavorability percentage goes down to 13% in Richmond once you tell voters what this is, that it's non-profit, open-to-wall, tuition-free, a part of this school system.

[01:33:49] And so I think we don't want to overplay the idea that people are anti. It's new Richmonders, y'all. Things that are new, right? And so we are spending a lot of time with people, reminding them that old things can be new.

[01:34:05] Again, we have been about innovation. our favorite schools would be charter schools today open high school community high school these are places that would be charter school franklin military academy these are these are charter schools of their day so reminding people of that and and really people are really excited about a middle school in particular middle school is a place where rich mothers are very very worried no matter your income no matter your race no matter where you live and i think parents of middle schoolers are just worried anyway middle school's a tough age but we really we are seeing a lot more people say can it be here can it be near me than we are seeing people say please don't

[01:34:44] bring that here we've seen some neighborhoods say we've got a building that sits empty that we would love to see the opportunity to have a school and a collaborative after school program which the Harvard School is like because we're an independent public school we can have those conversations a lot easier we can navigate a community partnership um a lot more easily so we'd love to be in a place where we could do something like that and there's a couple there's there's two spots that we aren't ready the folks aren't ready for us to be talking publicly about that yet um but i see us being

[01:35:16] away from i see us northern eastern or southern parts of the city more than western parts of the city what we don't want to do is is miscommunicate who the school is for through our location and Richmond has some particularities around where people live.

[01:35:34] So north, east, and south is where you'll find the Harbor School. Thank you. Appreciate that. A couple other areas. One is around discipline. So I appreciate in your materials you talk about policies that are geared toward restorative justice as opposed to policies being more punitive.

[01:35:56] Lots of research out there now about the efficacy of said restorative justice practices versus some traditional methods of discipline. And so I really want you guys to talk a little bit about, A, how you arrived at this as the policies that you will pursue, and then just how flexible are you based on what happens on the ground.

[01:36:17] Kick this one off and let you all add. As a part of the Richmond Public School District, we would be part of the discipline policies that are in Richmond. And as is true in any school, you play out those things on the ground, but I want to be really, really clear that those policies apply and we understand that.

[01:36:39] When we think, and I hear you about restorative practices, can be weak in their effectiveness at times. So here's a philosophy that drives our understanding of discipline that's really important. What we see and what we believe is that so much discipline comes from a conflict of culture.

[01:36:58] It comes from a place where an adult is expecting one set of behavior and a kid is doing another set of behavior. That's where the conflict happens. So one of the things that we really do on the front end is try to prevent that from happening in the first place in this onboarding and teaching.

[01:37:14] Let us teach you how we work here. Let us teach you how we live and work together here in this relationship building aspect. this opportunity of teaching young people to have relationships with one another and with adults as part of the core of the model and so discipline is that's a really good spot to be talking about here's how we here's how we live and work together here are the norms that we expect and to do a lot of positive reinforcement in those early days when you are doing the things the way that we want them to be done we're giving you a lot of positive feedback around that versus the negative feedback and but also correction early on right a

[01:37:50] a lot of real focus early on on let's get the culture right so that discipline goes down in the long run. And I think if we're seeing a lot of discipline issues, then the question needs to be what's wrong in the context and how do we get that right versus continue to accelerate on the discipline part. There do need to be consequences for young people. We can't just talk about something and assume it's better, but those don't need to be punitive either. They need to be natural consequences. What's a natural consequence? Hey, y'all had committed to getting X project done

[01:38:26] by Y time. Are we there? Well, we're not there yet. Gosh, some other young people have finished what they're doing and they're headed to do this elective 15 minutes over here. Looks like you guys are going to need to keep working as a consequence rather than a punishment. I understand and that's not discipline, but the idea being that whatever is going on is tied to what's happening in the room.

[01:38:52] I do think there are times when young people need time away from school to reset, and that suspension policies occasionally are what's needed. So it's not that we think that's never, but we would love to couch those in. These are times a way to recover and come back and have a return that is thoughtful.

[01:39:10] students just come back. We come back and we talk about what happened. We talked about how we're going to make it better. And then we keep moving forward so that the relationship is restored as we do that. Kristen, what am I missing on the technical language front? Or where am I making a mess that I shouldn't? That was thorough, I think. I think also just considering family, families too, and how do we include families and engage families in these conversations as well. So

[01:39:39] So even, it's not just at the time of discipline, but actually as we're onboarding, how are we having these conversations with the families that we're supporting to make sure that we're on the same level?

[01:39:55] So when any instances like this do happen, their voice is also loudly, and probably they even lead the conversation versus it. I'm so glad you said that because we have seen that when the teacher and the parent get aligned, all of a sudden kids move forward real fast.

[01:40:19] So as much as we can do that early on through regular conversations, it was amazing to watch one of our young people suddenly understand that mom was on board with us. Things got different real quick. And so having those meetings and those conversations early on, the weekly calls from the family liaison that then filter back into the classroom, we believe is going to be a prevention of the need for intense discipline or we that is the goal. If I may just a point of order during our during our presentation we mentioned one of the parents who asked for our school and

[01:40:55] who knocked on those doors we want to acknowledge that she was here and she was able to get here from work thank you for coming. Thank you. So I think you you read my mind it's actually where I was going to go next which is your model calls for a strong partnership with parents including the role of parent liaison roles of parents on your your management committee and some requirements some pretty stiff requirements for parent engagement as a part of the the contract that the student

[01:41:27] signs up for during this school school day talk to me a little bit about like how you plan to enforce that right to the point that we were making earlier parents have obligations that are outside of the school day and yet we want parents to be critical to the infrastructure of this school how are you hoping to to have that play out once the school is locked that's a lot about us going to them and less about them coming to us at times so in other words we think about the requirement for participation that includes answering the phone and chatting with us about how

[01:42:06] kids are doing don't misread that as you got to come and plant a garden with us in order to count as your participation in school this is about those moments of conversation and counting all the ways that that parents are supporting their young people in schools and yes what we would love to see is that that parents are coming to school caregivers are coming to school to see a really cool project we plan for expo nights you might call them of young people celebrating what they what they're learning and having folks come in and see what they're learning we really hope that that our caregivers

[01:42:42] will feel really welcome there and be part of that but the threshold for participation isn't about pushing people out it's about inviting people in and and monitoring that on our end to say what do we need to change to make this more possible for this family more than what if they need to change in order to meet our expectations it is a it is a watchfulness on our ourselves as much as it is anybody else are we missing anybody do we know everybody is are we um doing the work that we need to reach to families and create welcome for them um and it is really about participating

[01:43:19] not about checking the boxes like answer the phone is really the important piece of that answer text be in relationship with us in some way um what would you add to it's like being innovative when you think around family engagement because I think a lot of times people do say that, okay, we're going to do an event and do that here versus, and this is part of onboarding as well, so when you're thinking about when you're bringing families together and you're having these conversations of what does you mean to be part of this school, hearing from them of, like, what does engagement look like for you and how do you kind of see, what can you bring to the table

[01:43:58] and really kind of see it more as, like, assets and talents that they have they can bring to the table and so you might learn that like virtually they can kind of do something they can maybe be on like a zoom call they can be the one running the whatsapp chat they can do like all these things that they probably do on a daily basis that is their strong points that are strength and be able to really add that and integrate that I think also what's valuable is that family liaison is also going to be part of that leadership of the school, not just someone where it's nice to have and it's attached.

[01:44:39] So that really integrates families into what the school is doing on an everyday basis versus just saying this is something that we do on the side. This is actually how we lead and think and center community and family.

[01:44:55] I would add there's a flexibility on who is that adult so I think about a young man who is a part of our homeschool pod Jaden that you heard from his family circumstance doesn't allow for his mother to be involved in his school now and I am that person in his life for his school they have someone to talk to about how he's doing and we would do the same thing I've in all the years I've been around kids there's always an adult somewhere um that cares about that young person and our job is to find that person um and bring them into the conversation not say you're not the biological mom

[01:45:31] now hear me say we would not ask a person like me to do legal things on behalf of that child but to participate alongside that child and support that child's planning and support that child's dream along with us absolutely that qualifies got it okay final question for me And I really want to pick back up on President Creasy's questions around assessment.

[01:45:54] So you guys mentioned, like, you lay out your whole learning progression. You talk about things like knowledge checks. I'm assuming you will land on some sort of interim assessment to gauge growth. And obviously you've got the SOLs, which measure the seminar assessment.

[01:46:12] My question is, knowing that the population that you're targeting will likely come to you years behind, you've got three short years, you mentioned the eighth grade year assessment as being kind of a marker for you all, like what is your plan for retention and promotion if a hypothetical student comes to you on a first grade reading level?

[01:46:39] They've made tremendous progress, and they are now up to a fifth grade, but they are not yet at middle school middle school level when it's time for eighth grade what is what is your your plan for students that are so severely behind this isn't a knock on your ability to to catch them up it's just the three years it's hard to come back seven years in three years absolutely it's just what's real um so it's a great question and one we've wrestled with an

[01:47:06] awful lot. I think the place that that conversation starts is at onboarding season of sixth grade where you've come in and we've discovered, hey, we've got this big gap. It's really important that we begin

talking to a learner and talking with a caregiver about here's where we really are.

[01:47:35] We have really found that our caregivers and the parents that we've worked with are really craving knowledge on how is my child really doing. And they really welcome an honest assessment of here's where we are. Your child is reading at a fifth grade level. They're doing math at a second grade level. We've got some work to do. So let's begin to make a plan to do that work. Here's where we're going to start. Let's start with there's some opportunity to stay a little longer during the day to work on that. And there's some opportunity to really work at being attentive to those things. That's where this competency tracking really helps us. We can really see how

[01:48:11] fast a kid is progressing. And within that first year, I do think there's an opportunity, and we would look for an opportunity to say to a caregiver and a student, we think you'd benefit from four years here rather than three. Let's begin to talk about whether or not that makes sense.

[01:48:29] Do we want to do that all the time? No, but we think that conversation needs to be had. And had early, then we don't see as many of the negatives of retaining a student. Those negatives have a lot to do with social interaction. I have not progressed with my peers. I'm in that pod of 108 students where that student stays the entire time. They don't, they don't, your pod is your pod. Those are your 107 people. There is a mixed age group. So if you are in sixth grade this year, you're going to have sixth graders coming in next year. You're going to have relationships with those

[01:49:02] students you can progress with that next group without as much social stigma as being retained in a grade when we begin to work on it early we we believe we can close a lot of gaps but that would be the conversation with folks about let's plan for that early let's reclassify rather than retain and i would just add that we have really regular conferences every trimester with the parents and the whoever else is on this child learning team and so it would never come as a surprise we're tracking that every time oh we're making up we're growing so fast this isn't a

[01:49:40] concern anymore or we've all been expecting this this is going to take a little bit longer so celebrate the growth you have made question increasing my interrupt please oh wonderful um i really appreciate the members of the committee's uh questions um as well as the harbor team's response to i think you know lots of questions around how do we serve the students and families who really need us the most um and i think you all have answered it from some so many

[01:50:15] different perspectives whether it's relationships or it's data it's the curriculum it's the assessment and i mean this this is the challenge there is no best way to serve the students and families who need us the most if it were being done we wouldn't be in this room and so i i just want to you know again i think it raises the question that we all are faced with as educators as leaders um in the state um and i think the team has really thoughtfully um tried to tackle it um has jumped kind of both feet in you know and i applaud the applaud the community and i applaud

[01:50:54] the members of our community for really pushing on this issue because um serving the easiest kids is easy although there are no easy kids and we all know that's right i do yes uh appreciate the the committee's um just thoughtfulness with that um and with that i i would ask um president creasy uh serving as ex officio you know to really just uh rack up with any final questions see if there's any final thoughts as we then um really um take consideration of this application so thank you Any further or final questions before we wrap up?

[01:51:35] Okay. So the committee will now take a consensus vote. Well, in that case, I have a question. Okay. And the question is this. If we say move forward, do they have to submit the exact same application to the board, Or can they tweak it based on the conversations here today to elaborate, explain, whatever?

[01:52:03] Ms. McDaniel, do you want to answer that question?

[01:52:18] President and Member Bronleck, pursuant to our public charter school application process,

[01:52:55] We give the, if the committee decides that there's overall consensus that the board criteria is satisfied, the application will be recommended and presented to the board. And then secondly, if the committee decides that not all criteria is satisfied, the applicant will be provided time to address those criteria and be given a future opportunity to meet with the committee at a second meeting.

[01:53:16] Now, I will say in reference to the specific question of whether or not they have to provide the same application or if they can add additional items, we do not have that directly outlined in the process. I will say that within 10 days, I'm sorry, the applicant will receive written comments by members on strengths and suggestions for improving the overall charter proposal no more than five days.

[01:53:44] So I will ask Ms. Love, because our application process is silent on that point. So good afternoon.

[01:54:03] So what's the classic lawyer answer? It depends. And I'm sorry to do that, but, I mean, obviously it would make no sense for this committee to approve this application and have it transformed, be something different coming before the board.

[01:54:22] One, there's not time, but, well, you guys can accomplish a lot, so maybe some. So that doesn't seem appropriate. I think if the committee had, for example, and I'm just spitballing here, let's say there were some concerns about a particular thing. Maybe there's an element of this where maybe the committee's not satisfied that the board's criteria have been met.

[01:54:42] That would be appropriate fodder for conversation, and it might well be, as Ms. McDaniel noted, if the application's not approved, The options for the applicant are to come back to the committee. They can ask to come back with something that they think addresses the committee's concerns.

[01:55:01] They can also go on to the board, and I suppose they could also address those concerns. I would certainly think that the board, and President Creasy can speak to this better than anybody, the board would want to know what's different, you know, because they need to rely on the work of the committee.

[01:55:19] But if we change an apple to an orange, right, we're going to get a different kind of juice. The torture of metaphor. So I don't know if that's helpful guidance on that question. May I recommend if there is any additions that you would like to see if you decide ultimately that it satisfies board's criteria that the applicant can submit, perhaps an addendum that is specified,

[01:55:47] So that way, when it goes to the State Board of Education, the State Board now sees the original application that was submitted and then an addendum that does provide the feedback that the applicant took the time to prepare in reference to feedback that you all submit today.

[01:56:03] That works. I mean, I ask the question partly because whatever document the Board considers is the document that will probably be reported on by news media and by other individuals, both pro and con.

[01:56:19] I do think that there are some phrasing in here, as I pointed out, that I think you might want to clarify it's your option. But I sure as heck wouldn't want to see you have to go through, I'm telegraphing my vote, but to see you have to go through all this again, or us to have to go through it again.

[01:56:39] We would certainly welcome, I mean, the opportunity to clarify in some places. If that were an option, that would feel, look, we want to get better all the time. We deeply believe this idea that learning is getting it wrong and getting it right and making it better. So we certainly welcome an opportunity to clarify and to improve.

[01:56:59] Yeah, because the questions we had are questions other people are going to have, so you might as well short-circuit them. Let's get better at the time. Okay. So I think we'll proceed in that manner, Ms. Love, if that's okay, and just do an addendum with any comments that need addressing pre-board.

[01:57:22] And I think that that would certainly satisfy a more transparent approach to what has been given as feedback here and how you have addressed that feedback in an addendum sort of process there.

[01:57:40] Okay, any other process-oriented questions before we move on? Okay, so we'll first vote on whether the standing committee finds the application satisfies the board's approval criteria with respect to feasibility mr. Green do you have a comment to make thank you and what is the purpose of your abstention thank you okay so can I have

[01:58:15] a motion that this I'm sorry may I have a motion that the Standing Committee finds the application satisfies the board's approval criteria with respect to feasibility okay it was moved by Miss Ashton and seconded by Miss Lee all those in favor indicate by saying aye we don't have to have a roll call do we i don't believe so miss love no roll call vote

[01:58:52] required thank you sorry i i am in my board mentality okay that motion passes um we will next vote on whether the uh standing committee finds the application satisfies the board's approval with with respect to the criteria around curriculum can i have a motion that the standing committee finds the application satisfies the board's approval criteria with respect to curriculum so moved second all those in favor please indicate by saying aye all right okay that motion also

[01:59:28] passes we will now vote on whether the standing committee finds the application satisfies the board's approval criteria with respect to financial soundness may i have a motion that the standing committee finds the application satisfies the board's approval with respect criteria with respect to financial soundness.

[01:59:51] So moved. It's been moved and seconded. All those in favor indicate by saying aye. Aye. Okay. Ms. Ashton? Aye. You're fine. All right. That motion passes.

[02:00:08] Can I have a motion that the standing committee finds? The application satisfies the board's approval criteria with respect to all other objective criteria. So moved.

[02:00:25] Second. Okay, it's been moved and seconded. All those in favor indicate by saying aye. Aye. Aye. Okay, that motion passes. Lastly, we will have a vote on whether the standing committee finds that the overall application satisfies the board's approval criteria.

[02:00:45] May I have a motion to that effect? So moved. Second. All those in favor indicate by saying aye. Aye. Okay. That motion passes. So the committee has voted to advance this application for consideration by the Virginia Board of Education. This will take place during the business session on May 22nd.

[02:01:14] As a reminder, this is only the first step for this public charter school application pursuant to the charter school application process and the public charter school statute. This application now proceeds to the board of education who will determine whether the public charter school application satisfies the board's approval criteria just by way of a reminder all of the committee's written and oral feedback will be captured in a report that will be prepared by staff and presented to the board we will work with you all additionally on that amend i mean

[02:01:49] addendum process to amend those particular sections or add to them for further clarification upon a successful recommendation from the board of education the public charter school application will be forwarded to the local school board for their own determination as they are the final authorizer as you all know that um are there any current yes sir i i'm curious about the timeline this is may 8th if we have 10 days that's may 18th and how do we meet the how does the board meet the requirement to post things well enough in advance.

[02:02:29] Madam President, to address Member Bromlich's question, we're going to try to get that feedback and work with the applicant to get it done in time for public notice, and that is what we will try to do. So we are cognizant of everyone's timelines, and we'll take that into account should we need to. So are there any current issues that any member of the committee would like to address before we move on i got a

[02:03:03] question uh chair will increase this question is for sophia do we have any current um potential applicants or applications coming forward that you foresee over the next few months i have not been indicated by any potential applicant that they will be coming forward in the next few months as of right now. Further questions? Good. Okay. Since I don't believe there are any non-agenda items for public comment, I will, however, open it up. Is there anyone here who would like to

[02:03:41] speak on non-agenda items at this standing committee meeting? In that case, I will take a motion to adjourn. So moved. All right. And we are done. Thank you.